PACE Communication Plans

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Introduction: What is PACE?

PACE is a framework for planning redundant communications, so that you always have a way to communicate with your people. It stands for:
Primary: Your main, go-to communication method. The one you use every day.
Alternate: A backup nearly as capable as your primary, but uses different infrastructure.
Contingency: A more limited option for when both primary and alternate fail.
Emergency: The last resort. May be slow or inconvenient, but works when all else fails.

Key PACE Principles

Independence: Each tier should rely on different infrastructure. If your primary and alternate both need cell towers, you really only have three tiers.
Training: Your whole group must know how to use all four methods.
Practice: And do so regularly. The worst time to learn is during an emergency.
Triggers: Define when to shift from one tier to the next. Don't wait too long!

Tips for Building Your PACE Plan

Know Your Threat Model

What are you planning for? A protest where cell service gets overloaded? A disaster that takes out power for days? Bad actors intercepting your comms?

Ensure True Independence

Each tier should rely on different infrastructure. If your primary and alternate both need cell towers, you really only have three tiers. Good independence looks like:

- Cell-based → Radio-based → Mesh Network → Physical

Triggers to Shift Communications Tiers

Define clear triggers so your group knows when to switch to the next tier – or some members may be relying on methods others have stopped using. Some triggers are:

- Cell service or internet is down due to natural disasters or government action.
- GMRS service is jammed with novice operators.
- Mesh devices are not reaching each other due to damaged nodes.
- Starlink bandwidth is saturated due to overwhelming demand.
- 24 hours has passed during an active event without a check-in.

Keep It Simple

The best plan is one people will actually follow. If your contingency method is a 20-step process, it will fail under stress. Choose methods your group can learn and execute.

Real-World PACE Examples

Family of Preppers

P: A group Signal thread
A: Pre-programmed GMRS radios
C: Meshtastic / Meshcore devices
E: A set meeting place

Wilderness Search and Rescue Team

P: UHF/VHF radios on team frequencies
A: Cell phone when in coverage areas
C: Satellite messenger (i.e. Garmin inReach)
E: Whistle signals or returning to base camp

Sample Activist PACE Plan with Triggers

Primary: Signal

- Switch to alternate if Signal is unavailable for 15 minutes during an active event.

Alternate: GMRS Radios

- Switch to contingency if GMRS is congested, jammed, or monitored by hostile actors – or if there is a need for encrypted comms.

Contingency: Meshtastic / Meshscore

- Switch to emergency if devices not connecting, lost, confiscated, or destroyed.

Emergency: Physical Meetup Point

- Check once an hour to see if other methods are available again.

Print your PACE Plan on a Card!

Then laminate the card and make sure everyone in your group has a copy. Include:

- ✔ Which methods to use in which order
- ✔ Specific channels, frequencies, or addresses
- ✔ Triggers for when to shift to the next tier
- ✔ Emergency meeting location and check-in times

Practice Regularly

Schedule regular drills where you practice using your backup methods:

- "No-cell Sunday": Coordinate your group using only GMRS radios for a day.
- Comms blackout drill: Simulate Signal going down; switch to your alternate and time how long it takes to reach everyone.
- Equipment check: Verify batteries are charged, frequencies are correct, and everyone remembers how to use each device.

PACE Plan Checklist

- ☐ Each tier uses different infrastructure (cell, radio, mesh, physical)
- ☐ Triggers for tier shifts are clearly defined
- ☐ Everyone in the group knows all four methods
- ☐ Everyone has the necessary equipment for all four methods
- ☐ Frequencies/channels/addresses are documented and shared
- ☐ Plan has been tested in the last 90 days
- ☐ Batteries and equipment have been checked recently

Conclusion

A PACE plan is only as good as your commitment to practicing it. The methods you choose matter less than your group's ability to actually use them under pressure. Start simple, drill regularly, and refine as you learn what works for your community.